

CUYAHOGA COUNTY BOARD OF HEALTH

YOUR TRUSTED SOURCE FOR PUBLIC HEALTH INFORMATION

July 27, 2020

The Honorable David Greenspan
State Representative
House District 16
77 South High Street
Columbus, OH 43215

Dear Representative Greenspan:

Thank you for your July 23rd communication regarding data on Zip Code-specific metrics for 44070, 44116, 44126, 44140 and 44145.

In your communication, you note the 7 metrics for which the Ohio Department of Health collects data at the county level to populate the risk communication system established for the state. A number of the data points used to present the state metrics are not available below the county level and some are regional metrics. These limitations relate most directly to the metrics that tie to clinical data (metrics 4-7), which are provided by the Ohio Hospital Association and may be accessible through individual hospitals in the region. Additionally, some of these metrics are reliant upon testing capacity which continues to change. based on supply chain availability, thus decisions should not solely be based upon testing data.

We provide a color-coded Zip Code map of COVID cases in Cuyahoga County in our Data Briefs, which are released every Friday afternoon and are available along with other relevant data on our website (www.ccbh.net/coronavirus). Please note that there are limitations to consider in use of the Zip Code map, which could be subject to misinterpretation. **It's important to recognize that the map is not intended to indicate exposure risk at any specific geographic level, as it only indicates the residence of COVID-19 cases and not where someone may have been exposed.**

To date, we have had conversations with over 8,000 COVID-19 cases in our jurisdiction during the last 5 months and are have tracked approximately 9,000 close contacts of these cases. The data clearly indicate that people are exposed across the entire region and beyond, including at work, parties, funerals, weddings, congregate settings like longterm care facilities, religious ceremonies, bars, restaurants and on vacation in places like Florida, Texas and California. Consequently, we believe that sub-county/zip code data is not a reliable method that school districts should use for determining COVID transmission risk at a hyper-local level, like a zip code or municipality.

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Terrence M. Allan, R.S., M.P.H. Health Commissioner

Infectious diseases don't recognize borders and readily transmit via exposures to positive people who interact widely throughout Northeast Ohio and beyond. All of our response activities are based on our community testing capacity to rapidly identify and report cases of COVID -19 to the health department for investigation and contact tracing. Currently, there is very limited capacity to test children in our community and across the state. Additionally, the Centers for Disease Control and Prevention (CDC) recently stated that COVID-19 case numbers may be ten times higher than reported by testing as the vast majority of cases go unreported (<https://thehill.com/policy/healthcare/504552-cdc-coronavirus-may-have-infected-10-times-more-americans-than-known>). Consequently, the logical default approach is to presume that each of us may be a potential transmitter of COVID and that high utilization of masks, social distancing, sanitation and other proven prevention practices in all settings are the best way to reduce the risk for community transmission (<https://www.cdc.gov/coronavirus/2019-ncov/prevent-getting-sick/prevention.html>).

The County Board of Health (CCBH) has partnered with the Educational Services Center of Northeast Ohio (ESC) since the beginning of the pandemic to provide regular updates and current information to all of the school districts in Cuyahoga County. Over the last several weeks, we have held three countywide webinars with ESC for school district to discuss school reopening plans and have reviewed many aspects of the issues described in your letter and my response with the all of the school districts. We have also created a School Guidance web page that includes a Q&A for school districts that is updated on a regular basis (<https://www.ccbh.net/covid-19-school-guidance/>).

We're committed to continue this dialogue going forward to provide the most evidence-based guidance and answer questions amid a great deal of uncertainty for our community and school districts as we progress through this unprecedented pandemic.

Sincerely,

A handwritten signature in black ink, appearing to read 'T. Allan'.

Terry Allan, MPH
Health Commissioner

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